to be discovered. Humans rely on biodiversity for food, fuel, shelter, medicine, beauty, and pleasure. For other species, it provides nutrients, seed dispersal, pollination, and reproductive success. No living thing can survive without biodiversity.

Ecologists have identified growing threats to biodiversity, many of them driven by human actions. The current rate of species extinction may be 1,000 times greater than it was before 1800, when humans began to dominate the planet. The first use of the term “biodiversity,” in 1988, was by American biologist Edward O. Wilson, who became known as the “father of biodiversity.” He later highlighted five key threats to biodiversity using the acronym HIPPO: habitat destruction; invasive species; pollution; human population; and overharvesting by hunting and fishing.